

TYPES OF UTOPIANS

Why am I writing this?

If you regularly debate people with different political views, you have probably noticed that political labels alone are terrible descriptions of actual people.

This sounds obvious, yet it still needs to be said.

The sentence:

“I am a socialist.”

tells me almost nothing about the person saying it.

It tells me something about his preferred political system. It does not tell me how seriously he believes in it, how he treats people who disagree with him, whether he wants to convince them or punish them, or whether he even cares about the ideology beyond what it can personally give him.

The same applies to ancaps, national socialists, communists, conservatives, ancoms, religious movements, and practically everyone else.

Two people can use the same ideological label while being completely different human beings.

I therefore find it more useful to distinguish between several recurring types of ideologues.

The Missionary

The Missionary is the nicest one.

He genuinely believes his ideology would improve people's lives, and, importantly, he genuinely likes people.

He does not look at somebody with the wrong opinion and immediately see an enemy.

He sees someone who has not understood yet.

So he explains.

Enthusiastically.

Patiently.

Usually for much longer than anybody asked him to.

His basic attitude is:

“Bro, let me explain. I am trying to emancipate you.”

The word emancipate is important.

The Missionary thinks people are trapped.

Maybe by capitalism.

Maybe by the state.

Maybe by religion.

Maybe by tradition.

Maybe by propaganda.

Maybe by some other structure that prevents them from understanding how much better life could be.

And because the Missionary is fundamentally sympathetic, he assumes that once people understand their oppression, they will want to leave it.

That is also his greatest mistake.

Sometimes people are deceived.

But sometimes they are not.

Sometimes a person fully understands the system he supports and still supports it because the system benefits him, protects something he values, gives him status, gives him security, or simply reflects values that are different from yours.

The Missionary often has difficulty accepting this.

He thinks:

“Nobody could sincerely want this if they truly understood it.”

Unfortunately, people are perfectly capable of understanding horrible systems and sincerely preferring them anyway.

That is why Missionaries are often politically naive.

But I still like them.

They are pleasant people to debate.

They usually do not hate you for disagreeing.

They want to bring you into their beautiful future, not punish you for refusing it.

Jacque Fresco is a very good example of the Missionary archetype.

From a libertarian perspective, his economic views were terrible.

But he was a good guy.

Fresco did not come across as someone looking for enemies. He came across as someone who genuinely believed he had discovered a better way for people to live and desperately wanted everyone else to understand it too.

He could talk for hours because he honestly believed that explanation mattered.

If somebody disagreed, he didn't say:

"You are evil."

He said:

"You do not understand yet. Let me explain."

That is the Missionary mindset almost perfectly.

The Missionary does not enjoy having opponents.

He would much rather turn an opponent into a friend.

He believes people can be emancipated through understanding, and that once they finally see what he sees, they will want the same future.

That assumption may be terribly naive.

But it is also what makes Missionaries so pleasant compared to Sectarians.

How do you recognize a Missionary?

Very easily.

Ask him about his ideology.

If his eyes light up and he immediately starts telling you how much better your own life would be under it, you probably found one.

The Missionary does not primarily talk about enemies.

He talks about possibilities.

He wants you to understand.

He wants you to join.

He thinks you can still be convinced.

And even when his economics are catastrophic, that basic human attitude is hard for me to dislike.

The Sectarian

The Sectarian is not simply someone with strong political beliefs. Strong beliefs are normal. The problem begins when disagreement stops being disagreement and starts being treated as evidence that the other person is morally defective.

The Missionary hears an opposing opinion and thinks: "You are wrong. Let me explain why." The Sectarian hears exactly the same opinion and thinks: "You are the kind of person who believes this, so you should be treated differently now."

That is the difference.

A Sectarian can know someone for years, like him, trust him, laugh with him, and have no serious problem with his behavior. Then one politically unacceptable opinion appears. Maybe it concerns abortion, immigration, war, socialism, religion, Trump, gender, nationalism, or whatever subject his political tribe currently considers sacred.

Nothing about the actual person has changed. Nobody was attacked, cheated, threatened, or betrayed. The Sectarian simply learned what the other person believes.

And suddenly friendship may become unacceptable.

That is disgusting.

Not because anyone owes anyone friendship. Everyone is free to end a relationship. The problem is what this reveals about the Sectarian's way of judging human beings. Years of direct experience with a real person can suddenly matter less than one political opinion.

The Sectarian does not judge the person first and the ideology second. He judges the ideology first and then adjusts his opinion of the person accordingly.

That is why Sectarians are obsessed with ideological purity. They constantly need to know who is acceptable, who is suspicious, who follows the wrong account, who has the wrong friends, who liked the wrong post, who voted for the wrong candidate, who failed to condemn somebody loudly enough, and who once said something politically unacceptable three years ago.

Online, the stereotype is almost embarrassingly easy to recognize. The profile contains a list of people who must not interact. The biography explains which political groups are hated. The posts constantly announce who should be blocked, reported, excluded, fired, banned, or publicly humiliated.

A Sectarian rarely needs to be discovered.

He will tell everyone who he hates before he tells them who he is.

That is one of the clearest warning signs.

The second warning sign is punishment.

The Missionary wants to change an opinion. The Sectarian wants consequences for having the opinion.

Imagine a group of friends having dinner. One person says something politically unpopular. Nobody is personally insulted. Nobody is threatened. Nothing happens except an argument.

A normal group argues.

Maybe the argument becomes loud. Maybe everyone tells the person that the opinion is idiotic. Then the conversation ends and dinner continues.

The Sectarian behaves differently.

Afterward, private messages begin:

“Are we really going to keep inviting him after what he said?”

That sentence contains the entire personality.

The argument is already over. The next objective is social punishment.

Or imagine someone discovers that a longtime friend voted for the wrong candidate. Yesterday that friend was trustworthy, funny, generous, and pleasant company. Today the Sectarian decides that friendship itself is unacceptable because of the vote.

The friend did not change overnight.

The category changed.

The same thing happens constantly in online communities, university clubs, workplaces, hobby groups, and political spaces. Somebody expresses an unpopular opinion completely unrelated to the actual purpose of the group. The Sectarian immediately demands removal.

Not because the person threatened anyone.

Not because he harassed anyone.

Not because he disrupted the community.

His opinion alone is treated as sufficient reason to exclude him.

That is ordinary Sectarianism.

No dictatorship is required. No revolutionary tribunal is required. A Discord server and one self-righteous moderator are more than enough.

Relationships provide another obvious example. Two people may genuinely like each other, trust each other, and treat each other well. Then politics comes up and one opinion fails the purity test.

The relevant question should be simple:

Does this person actually treat others well?

The Sectarian replaces it with:

Does this person possess the correct beliefs?

That replacement is the problem.

Family arguments can work exactly the same way. A relative says something stupid about politics at dinner. A normal person can argue, become annoyed, mock the opinion, and continue treating the relative as a relative.

The Sectarian starts discussing whether the person should be excluded from future gatherings.

Again, the reason is not abusive behavior.

The reason is ideological impurity.

The vocabulary varies between political tribes, but the structure is simple:

Wrong opinion → bad person → punishment.

This does not mean every block, ban, friendship breakup, or exclusion is Sectarian. Sometimes people are abusive. Sometimes they harass others. Sometimes they repeatedly destroy every conversation. Sometimes a relationship simply becomes miserable.

The reason matters.

Ending a relationship because somebody treats others terribly is normal.

Ending an otherwise good relationship purely because somebody peacefully holds an unacceptable political opinion is a very different phenomenon.

That is the Sectarian pattern.

The scale of punishment can vary enormously. One Sectarian blocks somebody. Another tries to turn mutual friends against him. Another contacts an employer. Another organizes a campaign to remove him from

an online community. Another publishes private messages so that strangers can participate in the punishment.

These actions are obviously not equally serious.

The underlying logic is still recognizable:

The Missionary wants to prove the opponent wrong.

The Sectarian wants the opponent punished for being wrong.

Guilt by association is another common symptom.

Having acceptable opinions is often not enough. The Sectarian also demands acceptable friendships.

Following the wrong account becomes suspicious.

Remaining friends with somebody politically unacceptable becomes suspicious.

Appearing in a photograph with the wrong person becomes suspicious.

Refusing to cut somebody off becomes suspicious.

Eventually ideological purity is no longer measured only by beliefs. It is measured by social proximity to other people.

This creates one of the ugliest features of Sectarian social behavior: people stop choosing relationships according to actual human experience and start choosing them according to political risk.

A person may be kind, loyal, funny, generous, and trustworthy, yet association with him becomes dangerous because somebody else may notice his politics.

That is not tolerance.

That is social cowardice enforced by ideological policing.

And none of this belongs exclusively to one political tribe.

A socialist can be a Sectarian. A nationalist can be a Sectarian. A progressive can be a Sectarian. A conservative can be a Sectarian. A religious traditionalist can be a Sectarian. An anarchist can be a Sectarian. A libertarian can be a Sectarian.

Even an anarcho-capitalist can spend all day talking about freedom and still behave like a perfect Sectarian the moment somebody peacefully disagrees.

A self-described opponent of state coercion who reports a peaceful political opponent to state authorities because of political disagreement has already demonstrated something more important than the label in his profile.

A political label cannot rescue bad character.

That is precisely why labels are such poor descriptions of people.

The important question is not which ideological vocabulary a person learned.

The important question is what happens when somebody refuses to agree.

How do you recognize a Sectarian?

No elaborate psychological test is necessary.

Disagree peacefully about something important.

Then watch what happens.

Does the argument remain an argument?

Does the person ask questions?

Does he explain his own position?

Does he call the opinion stupid while continuing to treat the opponent normally?

Good.

Or does disagreement immediately change how the opponent is treated as a person?

Does friendship become conditional?

Does punishment enter the conversation?

Do other people suddenly need to be warned?

Does association with the dissenter itself become suspicious?

That is the Sectarian.

Another useful test is to compare how much time somebody spends discussing ideas with how much time he spends discussing unacceptable people.

Missionaries spend enormous amounts of time explaining the system they want.

Sectarrians spend enormous amounts of time identifying who should be condemned for opposing it.

Ideological intolerance is not intelligence.

It is not courage.

It is not moral seriousness.

A person who cannot tolerate peaceful disagreement without trying to punish the dissenter has failed one of the most basic requirements of living around other human beings.

One distinction summarizes the entire type:

The Missionary wants fewer opponents because he persuaded them.
The Sectarrian wants fewer opponents because he got rid of them.

Strong conviction is not Sectarianism. A person can consider somebody else's politics stupid, destructive, immoral, or completely insane and still recognize that the opponent remains a human being rather than a political problem to remove.

Once that distinction disappears, the problem is no longer merely the ideology.

The problem is the Sectarian.

The Opportunist

The Opportunist does not sell an ideology because he believes it.

He sells it because other people believe it.

That is the entire type.

The Missionary tells people beautiful stories because he sincerely thinks those stories describe a better future. The Sectarian believes the story so strongly that he starts treating dissenters as enemies. The Opportunist may consider the entire story nonsense.

He tells it anyway.

Why?

Because people give money to prophets.

They vote for saviors.

They follow leaders.

They donate to movements.

They accept authority from people who promise justice, freedom, equality, security, national greatness, revolution, liberation, or whatever other beautiful word happens to work on the intended audience.

The Opportunist understands this.

His ideology is not a destination.

It is a product.

He does not ask:

“Is this true?”

He asks:

“Will people believe it?”

And after that:

“What do they give me if they do?”

That is what separates him from every sincere ideologue.

A Missionary may spend years promoting an idea that makes him poorer, less popular, and less powerful because he genuinely believes the idea matters.

An Opportunist is much less romantic.

If the ideology stops paying, the ideology becomes negotiable.

If yesterday's slogan creates influence, he repeats it.

If tomorrow's slogan creates more influence, an astonishing intellectual evolution may occur overnight.

The words change.

The objective does not.

What does the Opportunist actually want?

Usually something painfully ordinary.

Money.

Power.

Status.

A career.

Followers.

Access to institutions.

Control over resources.

Sometimes simply the pleasure of being important.

The ideology provides a respectable explanation for why all of those things should be handed to him.

That is the trick.

Nobody wants to hear:

“Give me authority because having authority would be enjoyable.”

So the Opportunist says:

“Give me authority so that the people can finally be free.”

Nobody wants to hear:

“Give me your money because having your money would improve my life.”

So the Opportunist says:

“Support the movement. Together we can build a better future.”

The content changes from ideology to ideology, but the structure is embarrassingly stable.

The audience is promised paradise.

The Opportunist somehow receives the office.

How do you recognize an Opportunist?

One of the funniest clues is to listen carefully when he describes the wonderful society of the future.

Where is he standing in it?

Ordinary believers usually imagine themselves as ordinary participants.

A worker imagines better conditions.

An entrepreneur imagines greater freedom.

A Missionary imagines people finally enjoying the system he has spent years explaining.

The Opportunist has a suspicious tendency to imagine himself somewhere near the controls.

Not as one of the workers.

As the person organizing them.

Not as an ordinary member of the movement.

As its representative.

Not as somebody obeying the revolutionary committee.

As somebody sitting on it.

The future supposedly exists for everyone, yet somehow the person selling it keeps finding himself in management.

That does not prove opportunism by itself. Ambitious people can sincerely believe things.

The relevant pattern appears when personal incentives repeatedly predict ideological flexibility.

Watch what happens when the principle becomes expensive.

Does he keep it when it costs money?

Does he defend it when doing so costs popularity?

Does he apply it when it limits his own power?

Does he still believe in the rule when the rule benefits an opponent?

Or does every sacred principle suddenly acquire a fascinating collection of exceptions the moment obedience becomes inconvenient?

That is where the mask starts slipping.

The Opportunist adapts to the audience

Another useful sign is ideological shape-shifting.

The same person may sound radically different depending on who is listening.

To libertarians, he speaks about freedom.

To conservatives, order.

To progressives, justice.

To nationalists, sovereignty.

None of this is automatically dishonest. Real political beliefs can contain several values at once.

The warning sign is something else: there appears to be no principle that survives contact with an audience that rewards the opposite principle.

The rhetoric always moves toward whatever produces applause.

At that point, ideology stops looking like a belief system and starts looking like market research.

Opportunists love believers

The Opportunist does not necessarily hate Missionaries or Sectarians.

Quite the opposite.

They are useful.

Missionaries provide enthusiasm.

Sectarians provide loyalty.

Idealists provide free labor.

True believers defend the movement when criticism appears.

The Opportunist receives the benefit of conviction without having to suffer the inconvenience of possessing any.

This creates one of the oldest political arrangements in existence:

the believers make sacrifices while the Opportunist explains why the sacrifices are necessary.

The believers are told that history demands patience.

The Opportunist somehow acquires a larger office.

The believers are told that resources are scarce.

The Opportunist somehow remains comfortable.

The believers are told that personal ambition must be subordinated to the cause.

The Opportunist's personal ambition somehow becomes identical to the cause.

Very convenient.

The Sectarian and the Opportunist are almost opposites

The Sectarian may be cruel, intolerant, and unbearable, but he often means what he says.

He can destroy friendships for an idea.

He can lose opportunities for an idea.

In extreme cases, he can destroy himself for an idea.

The Opportunist finds this behavior incomprehensible unless the sacrifice produces something useful.

That gives the cleanest distinction between the two types:

The Sectarian may sacrifice himself for the ideology.

The Opportunist will sacrifice the ideology for himself.

That sentence is worth remembering.

The Sectarian is dangerous because he believes too much.

The Opportunist is dangerous because belief is optional. Basically, he is just a scammer.

Does every politician become an Opportunist?

No.

Seeking office does not automatically prove that somebody is lying about every political belief. Neither does changing an opinion. People learn things, compromise, make mistakes, and genuinely change their minds.

Calling somebody an Opportunist requires a pattern.

Repeated principles abandoned when inconvenient.

Repeated ideological shifts that align neatly with personal advantage.

Repeated promises whose main practical beneficiary is the person making them.

Repeated appeals to sacrifice from people who somehow never seem to share the sacrifice.

The important point is not to read minds.

It is to watch incentives.

A single contradiction may be stupidity.

A hundred contradictions, all pointing toward the same person's money, status, and power, begin to look less mysterious.

The simplest definition

The Missionary believes the story and wants everyone to understand it.

The Sectarian believes the story and wants dissenters punished.

The Opportunist has a different relationship with the story.

He needs you to believe it.

Whether he believes it himself is secondary.

That is why the Opportunist should never be judged by the beauty of his promises.

Judge what the promises consistently purchase for the person making them.

Which of these three types is actually right?

Nobody.

The Missionary hopelessly wastes resources trying to save those who consciously choose to remain slaves. The Sectarian turns out to be a degenerate and a useful idiot, obsessed with punishments and purges. The Opportunist functions as a primitive scammer, profiting off other people's illusions. None of them are right.

So what should you be instead? A rational individualist who maintains common sense, but stops trying to rescue those who refuse to be rescued. Saving those who fiercely resist any liberation is an absurd and thankless waste of time.

People are not equal, and that fact is neither good nor bad. People want different things. Some want anarcho-capitalism, some want North Korea. It is simply reality.

Do not waste your energy trying to convince people who repeatedly demonstrate that they neither value freedom nor wish to take responsibility for it.

If someone says:

“All capitalists should die.”

answer

“No, thank you.”

You are not obligated to love such a person, nor do you have to hate them. They simply exist. Yes, they have no interest in building your vision of a better future with you, but that is entirely fine, you simply do not care. If they try to harm or kill you, of course you defend yourself. But until then, you remain utterly indifferent.

Keep it simple: talk to peaceful people, be kind, get a job, learn how to use crypto and Tor, touch some grass, spend more time outside, and focus on your actual life. If you want, share your ideas with sane individuals, but remember that counter-economy and practical common sense matter far more than internet theories.

Stay rational. Do not turn into sectarians, do not judge a person exclusively by political labels, and remain reasonable.

Be a Missionary, but stop being naive.

That's all :)

AUF!